

Chapter 4 — Differentiation and Mixed Ability

35 prompts

Differentiation fails when it quietly becomes three separate lessons running in one room, or when "support" turns into a permanently lower expectation. These prompts keep one destination and change the route: same objective, same closing discussion, different ways in.

WHAT'S IN HERE

GROUP	PROMPTS	USE WHEN
Scaffolds	8	Same task, more support
Tiered tasks	6	Three versions, one objective
Multilingual support	6	Language load down, expectation unchanged
Reading and accessibility	6	The text is the barrier, not the idea
Extensions	4	Real work for those who finish early
Flexible grouping	4	Who works with whom, and for how long

WORTH KNOWING BEFORE YOU START

Never name a student. Describe the need — "students reading about two years below grade level" — not the person.

Ask for neutral names for the routes. Anything that reads as a ranking will be decoded by the class within one lesson.

Push back if an extension is just more questions. Extension means harder thinking, not extra volume, and several prompts here say so outright.

Whatever accommodation you supply must survive into the draft. Check that it did.

SCAFFOLDS

DF-001 Add temporary scaffolds without lowering the goal

All grades

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Some of the class cannot start, and the target is not moving.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Add scaffolds to this [GRADE] [SUBJECT] task so more students can access it, without changing what the task demands.

Task: [PASTE IT]

Objective: [OBJECTIVE]

The barrier I am seeing: [DESCRIBE IT – not who has it]

Give me:

- Three scaffolds, each addressing a different barrier
- For each, exactly what changes on the page or in what I say
- For each, what the student still has to do themselves – the thinking the scaffold must not take over
- When and how each scaffold comes off

Do not simplify the content, reduce the number of steps in the reasoning, or turn an open question into a closed one. If a scaffold cannot be added without doing that, say so.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Does the student still do the thinking, or has the scaffold done it?
- Is the removal plan real, or "eventually"?

DF-005 Turn an observed barrier into a targeted support plan

Grades 3-5, 6-8, 9-12

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

You have watched them struggle and want to name what is actually in the way.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Here is what I observed in [GRADE] [SUBJECT] on [TOPIC]:

[DESCRIBE WHAT STUDENTS DID AND SAID. No names.]

Help me work out what the barrier actually is.

Give me:

- Three possible barriers consistent with what I described – for example prerequisite knowledge, reading demand, working memory load, unfamiliar format, or the task being unclear
- What I would see in each case that I am not seeing in the others
- A five-minute check that tells them apart
- The support that follows from each, and the support that would waste time if I picked the wrong one

Do not infer anything about a student's ability, home life, motivation or attention. Stay with what the work shows.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Does the check genuinely separate the three?
- Has it stayed with the work rather than the student?

DF-006 Create a graphic organizer that preserves essential reasoning

Grades 3-5, 6-8, 9-12

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Organisers often organise the thinking away.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Design a graphic organiser for this [GRADE] [SUBJECT] task: [TASK]

The organiser must hold the structure while leaving the reasoning to the student. Boxes that only need copying are not helping.

Give me:

- The organiser, described so I could draw it on a board
- What goes in each section, as the student sees it
- The one section where the actual thinking happens, and why it stays blank
- What a completed one looks like when it is done well
- What a completed one looks like when the student filled boxes without thinking

Then tell me what this organiser makes harder, since every structure closes something off.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Could a student fill this in correctly without understanding?
- Is the thinking still theirs to do?

DF-007 Write sentence frames at three levels of language support

Grades 3-5, 6-8, 9-12

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

They know the answer and cannot get it into a sentence.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Write sentence frames for [GRADE] [SUBJECT] students explaining [WHAT THEY MUST EXPLAIN].

Three levels of support:

- Heavy: most of the sentence given, student supplies the content words
- Medium: the structure given, student supplies the substance
- Light: a starter only

At every level the student must supply the reasoning. A frame that can be completed correctly without understanding is not a frame, it is a fill-in.

Give me 3-4 frames per level, plus one completed example each.

Then tell me how a student moves from heavy to light, and what tells me they are ready.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Could a student complete the heavy frames without understanding?
- Is there a route off the frames, or do they become permanent?

DF-008 Break a complex task into checkpoints without doing the thinking

Grades 3-5, 6-8, 9-12

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

The task is right; its size is what defeats them.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Break this [GRADE] [SUBJECT] task into checkpoints: [PASTE THE TASK]

Chunk it by natural decision points, not into equal-sized pieces. Each checkpoint should be somewhere a student could go wrong and not know it.

Give me:

- The checkpoints, with what the student has at each
- The self-check at each: how they know to continue rather than asking me
- What I look at if a student is stuck, to see which checkpoint they lost it at
- What the student still decides – the chunking must not remove the choices

Do not turn the task into a set of instructions to follow. If splitting it would do that, tell me and suggest a different support.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Has it become a recipe? Then the thinking is gone.
- Can a student self-check without you?

DF-009 Add worked examples and prompts with a clear fade plan

Grades 3-5, 6-8, 9-12

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Worked examples help, until they become the only thing students can do.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Build a faded sequence for [SKILL] in [GRADE] [SUBJECT].

Four stages:

1. Fully worked example, with the reasoning at each step
2. Same difficulty, last two steps blank
3. Same difficulty, only the first step given
4. Nothing given

The content difficulty must stay constant across all four. The only variable is support.

Give me the four stages, the answers, and:

- What tells me a student is ready to move on
- What it means if they can do stage 2 but not stage 4
- The point in this sequence students most often get stuck, and why

Do not make the later stages harder to compensate for having less support.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Is the difficulty genuinely constant across the four?
- Does the worked example show the thinking, or just the steps?

DF-010 Create a scaffold menu learners can choose from responsibly

Grades 3-5, 6-8, 9-12

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Students choosing their own support, without it becoming a way to avoid work.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Design a scaffold menu for this [GRADE] [SUBJECT] task: [TASK]

Students choose what support to take. Give me:

- 4-5 supports, each addressing a different difficulty
- The one-line description a student reads to decide
- What each support does not do, so nobody expects it to give the answer
- How a student takes one without announcing anything about themselves
- The prompt I use to get them to try without a support first

No support should be so complete that taking it removes the learning. Tell me which of yours comes closest to that line.

Do not label supports by level, ability, or in any order that reads as a ranking.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Which support would a student take to avoid thinking? Trim it.
- Can students take one privately?

DF-011 Audit classroom supports for dependence and hidden lower expectations

All grades

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

The supports have been in place a while and nobody has asked whether they should be.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Audit the supports I am using in [GRADE] [SUBJECT]:

[DESCRIBE THEM – what they are, who tends to use them, how long they have been in place. No names.]

Tell me:

- Which supports are doing the thinking rather than enabling it
- Which have quietly become permanent, and what that costs
- Where a support is really a lower expectation with a friendlier name
- Which students would now succeed without a support, and what evidence would confirm that
- Any support that marks out who receives it

Then tell me which one to remove first, how to remove it, and what to watch for afterwards.

Be blunt. A support that has been in place all year with no plan to remove it is the thing I most need to hear about.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Which support have you never questioned? Start there.
- Is any support visibly marking out who gets it?

TIERED TASKS

DF-002 Create three routes to the same objective

Grades 3-5, 6-8, 9-12

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Same destination, three ways in, one discussion at the end.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Build three routes to this [GRADE] [SUBJECT] objective: [OBJECTIVE]

Base task: [PASTE IT]

All three end at the same mastery check and feed the same closing discussion.

For each route give me:

- The task as students receive it
- What thinking it demands – this must be the same across all three
- What differs: the support, the representation, or the entry point
- What it produces for the closing discussion

Rules:

- Name them neutrally, in no order that reads as a ranking
- A student can move between routes without asking permission
- The extension route is harder thinking, not more questions

Then tell me how the closing discussion works when different students took different routes.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Could the class decode which route is "the easy one"?
- Does the closing discussion genuinely include all three?

DF-012 Build scaffolded, on-level and extension versions of one task

Grades 3-5, 6-8, 9-12

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

One task, three versions, running at the same time in one room.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Take this [GRADE] [SUBJECT] task and give me three versions: [PASTE IT]

- Scaffolded: same thinking, more support
- On-level: as written, tightened if it needs it
- Extension: same topic, genuinely harder thinking – not more items

All three must run in the same room at the same time, need the same materials, and finish in the same time.

Give me the three versions, and:

- What is identical across all three, and what changes
- Where I spend my time, and in what order
- The common check all three students complete
- What each version tells me that the others do not

If the extension is just more of the same, rewrite it before giving it to me.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Is the extension harder thinking, or more work?
- Do all three genuinely finish in the same time?

DF-013 Tier a task by representation rather than by easier content

Grades 3-5, 6-8, 9-12

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Changing how the idea is presented, not how demanding it is.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Tier this [GRADE] [SUBJECT] task by changing the representation, keeping the content demand identical.

Task: [PASTE IT]

Give me the same task presented:

- Concretely, with physical or visual materials
- Pictorially or diagrammatically
- Abstractly or symbolically

For each:

- The task as the student sees it
- What is genuinely the same about the thinking required
- Which students this representation helps, described by need, not by label
- How a student moves toward the abstract version

None of these is the easy version. If one has ended up less demanding, tell me and fix it.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Is the demand truly equal, or is the concrete one easier?
- Is there a path toward the abstract, or does it stop at concrete?

DF-014 Create three entry points with one common mastery product

Grades 3-5, 6-8, 9-12

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Different starts, identical evidence at the end.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Design three entry points into [TOPIC] for [GRADE] [SUBJECT], all producing the same final piece of evidence.

Objective: [OBJECTIVE]

Give me:

- Three openings, differing in how much prior knowledge they assume
- The point where all three converge
- The single mastery product every student produces, identical across entries
- What the product shows, and what it cannot show about the route taken
- How I mark it the same way regardless of entry point

A student's entry point must not be readable from their final product. If it would be, change the product.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Could you tell from the product which entry a student used?
- Do the three genuinely converge, or run in parallel to the end?

DF-015 Design tiered questions that move from access to transfer

Grades 3-5, 6-8, 9-12

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

A question set where everyone starts and the ceiling stays high.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Write a tiered question set on [TOPIC] for [GRADE] [SUBJECT].

Structure:

- 2 access questions anyone who attended the lesson can begin
- 3 core questions on the objective
- 2 transfer questions in a context we have not used

Every student attempts every tier. These are not ability groups and must not be labelled as such.

Give me the questions, the answers, and:

- What it means if a student is fine on core and stuck on transfer
- One transfer question a student who found the access questions hard could still attempt
- The question I would put on the board for the whole class

Do not make the transfer questions inaccessible to a struggling student. They should demand different thinking, not more prior knowledge.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Could a struggling student attempt at least one transfer question?
- Do the tiers demand different thinking, or the same thing harder?

DF-016 Check that every tier carries equal curricular dignity

Grades 3-5, 6-8, 9-12

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Before students work out which version is the one for "the bottom group".

COPY THIS PROMPT

Audit these tiered [GRADE] [SUBJECT] tasks for equal dignity.

Tell me:

- Whether any version is visibly the lesser one – in length, appearance, interest, or what students get to talk about afterwards
- Whether any version reduces the actual learning rather than the support
- What a student on each version would say if asked which group they were in
- Whether the naming, ordering or layout signals a ranking
- Whether every version has something worth sharing in the closing discussion

Then tell me the single change that would most equalise them, and whether any version should simply be removed.

TASKS:

[PASTE THEM]

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Which version would you least want to be given? That is the answer.
- Does every version get airtime at the end?

DF-017 Create a whole-class debrief that reconnects three task versions

Grades 3-5, 6-8, 9-12

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Three versions, and now everyone has to be in one conversation.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Design a [MINUTES]-minute closing discussion for a [GRADE] [SUBJECT] lesson where students worked on three versions of [TASK].

The discussion must work for all three without anyone having to announce which version they did.

Give me:

- An opening question every student can answer from their own version
- The order I take contributions in, so no version is heard as the authority
- Two questions that make the versions illuminate each other
- The shared conclusion everyone leaves with
- What I say if a student reveals which version they did, so it passes without weight

Do not structure it as the extension group reporting back to the others.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Does any version get positioned as the correct one?
- Can everyone answer the opening question?

MULTILINGUAL SUPPORT

DF-003 Make a task accessible to multilingual learners

All grades

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

The idea is within reach. The English wrapped around it is not.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Make this [GRADE] [SUBJECT] task accessible to students still developing English, without lowering what it demands.

Task: [PASTE IT]

Give me:

- The 5-6 words that will block comprehension, each with a plain definition and a visual I could sketch in ten seconds
- Sentence frames for the discussion
- A way to show understanding that does not require writing a paragraph
- One thing I should say differently while teaching
- The subject vocabulary that must stay, defined in place rather than removed

Reduce the language load only. Do not simplify the content, cut a step from the reasoning, or lower the expectation.

Do not assume anything about which language a student speaks at home.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Has content been simplified, or only language?
- Is the subject vocabulary still there?

DF-018 Identify the language demands hidden inside a subject task

Grades 3-5, 6-8, 9-12

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

The task is not about language, and language is why it is failing.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Analyse the language demands in this [GRADE] [SUBJECT] task: [PASTE IT]

Tell me:

- Command words, and what each actually asks for – students often lose marks on "explain" versus "describe" rather than on the content
- Subject vocabulary that must be understood versus general academic vocabulary that could be simplified
- Grammatical structures that carry meaning here – conditionals, passives, comparatives – and where a misreading changes the answer
- Any sentence a student could parse correctly and still misunderstand
- Cultural or contextual knowledge the task assumes without stating

Then tell me which single demand, if removed, would help most without changing what is assessed.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Does the task assume context knowledge you had not noticed?
- Are the command words used consistently across your papers?

DF-019 Build an essential vocabulary preview with visuals and examples

Grades 3-5, 6-8, 9-12

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Front-loading the words that would otherwise stop the lesson.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Build a vocabulary preview for a [GRADE] [SUBJECT] lesson on [TOPIC].

Keep it to the words that genuinely block understanding. A long list is a worse preview than a short one.

For each word give me:

- A student-friendly definition, using words simpler than the word itself
- An example and a non-example
- A visual I could sketch on the board in ten seconds
- The everyday meaning it might be confused with, if there is one

Then give me:

- The 5-minute routine for introducing them
- Which words students will still need in the moment, and how I support that
- Which of these words are worth keeping for the rest of the year

Do not include words students can work out from context. Say which ones those are.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Are the definitions genuinely simpler than the words?
- Is the list short enough to actually teach in five minutes?

DF-020 Create structured partner rehearsal before independent writing

Grades 3-5, 6-8, 9-12

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Saying it before writing it makes the writing possible.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Design a partner rehearsal step before [GRADE] [SUBJECT] students write about [TOPIC].

Give me:

- The exact instruction pairs hear, under 30 seconds
- What each partner does – both must speak, not one talking and one listening
- The frames a student uses if they cannot start
- How long each turn gets, and the signal to swap
- What the listening partner is responsible for noticing
- How the rehearsal connects to what they then write alone

The rehearsal must not become the answer being dictated. Tell me how to stop one partner writing the other's paragraph for them.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Does both students speaking actually happen, or does one dominate?
- Is the writing still their own after this?

DF-021 Plan purposeful home-language use without assuming proficiency

Grades 3-5, 6-8, 9-12

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Thinking in a first language is an asset, and should not be an assignment.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Plan how students might use a home language during this [GRADE] [SUBJECT] lesson on [TOPIC].

Constraints:

- Do not assume any student is literate in their home language, or wants to use it, or has anyone to use it with
- Do not assume which language any student speaks
- Everything must remain optional and unremarkable

Give me:

- Where in the lesson thinking in another language genuinely helps
- How I offer that without singling anyone out or making it an instruction
- What is produced in English regardless, so the assessment stays consistent
- What I do if a student declines

Then tell me where this would be a bad idea in this lesson, and why.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Could a student decline without it being noticed?
- Have you assumed anything about who speaks what?

DF-022 Separate content evidence from English-language evidence

Grades 3-5, 6-8, 9-12

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Marking science, and accidentally marking English.

COPY THIS PROMPT

For this [GRADE] [SUBJECT] task, separate what shows subject understanding from what shows English proficiency.

Task: [PASTE IT]

Objective: [OBJECTIVE]

Tell me:

- Which parts of a response evidence the subject learning
- Which evidence language ability rather than the objective
- Where a student with strong understanding and developing English would lose marks, and whether that is defensible here
- An alternative way to evidence the same objective with a lower language load
- What I should not correct, because it is not what I am assessing

Then give me a marking note I could write for myself so I stay consistent across thirty scripts.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Would a strong thinker with weak English pass this?
- Is your marking note specific enough to hold you to it?

READING AND ACCESSIBILITY

DF-004 Adapt text access while preserving meaning

Grades 3-5, 6-8, 9-12

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Keep the ideas. Lose the barrier.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Adapt the text below for [GRADE] students reading roughly [NUMBER] years below grade level.

Keep every key idea and all subject vocabulary – define the vocabulary in place rather than removing it. Shorten sentences, make the structure explicit, and add a heading every few paragraphs.

Give me:

- The adapted text
- What you changed, and anything nuanced that was lost in simplifying
- The 5 words a student may still get stuck on, with a student-friendly gloss
- Anywhere the original's meaning is genuinely ambiguous, so I know the simplification made a choice

Do not remove complexity that is the point of the text. If a passage cannot be simplified without losing its argument, say so and leave it.

TEXT:

[PASTE IT]

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Read both versions. Is the argument intact?
- Did it flag any choice it made on your behalf?

DF-023 Chunk a demanding source without rewriting its claims

Grades 6-8, 9-12

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

A primary source or original text that must stay in its own words.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Chunk this [GRADE] [SUBJECT] source for students, without altering its wording.

Give me:

- The natural chunk boundaries, quoting the first few words of each
- A one-line purpose for each chunk – what students are reading for
- A question after each chunk, answerable from that chunk alone
- The chunk students will find hardest, and the support that goes there
- The vocabulary gloss for each chunk, alongside rather than replacing the text

Do not paraphrase, modernise or simplify the source itself. The whole point is that students meet the original.

SOURCE:

[PASTE IT]

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Is the original wording untouched?
- Is each question answerable from its own chunk?

DF-024 Create a plain-language companion beside the original text

Grades 3-5, 6-8, 9-12

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Both versions on the desk, so students can move between them.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Write a plain-language companion for this [GRADE] [SUBJECT] text, to sit alongside the original rather than replace it.

Give me:

- A plain-language version, paragraph by paragraph, aligned to the original so students can match them
- Anything the plain version loses – nuance, tone, hedging, ambiguity
- Three places where the original says something more precisely than the plain version can
- A task that requires using both, so students have a reason to go back

Do not present the plain version as equivalent. It is a way in, not a replacement.

TEXT:

[PASTE IT]

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Does the task genuinely require the original?
- Are the losses it named ones you care about?

DF-025 Add glossary, guiding questions and audio-access suggestions

Grades 3-5, 6-8, 9-12

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Three supports around one text, without rewriting it.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Build a support pack around this [GRADE] [SUBJECT] text: [PASTE IT]

Give me:

- A glossary of the words that block meaning, in the order they appear, with student-friendly definitions
- 4 guiding questions placed at the points where a reader typically loses the thread
- Suggestions for making this available as audio, using what a school normally has – do not recommend paid tools or anything requiring a personal account
- What a student does before reading, during, and after

Then tell me which single support would help most if I only had time for one.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Do the audio suggestions work with what your school actually has?
- Are the guiding questions at the right points for your class?

DF-026 Reduce unnecessary reading load in a non-reading assessment

Grades 3-5, 6-8, 9-12

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

A maths test that is secretly a reading test.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Reduce the reading load in this [GRADE] [SUBJECT] assessment without changing what it assesses.

Assessment: [PASTE IT]

What it is meant to assess: [OBJECTIVE]

For each question:

- Say whether the reading demand is part of what is being assessed or is incidental
- Where incidental, rewrite it with lower reading demand and identical subject demand
- Flag anything where cutting the words would change the question

Then tell me:

- Which question currently disadvantages a weak reader most
- Whether the paper as a whole tests the objective or tests reading

Do not shorten questions by removing information students need.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Do the rewrites still test the same thing? Check each one.
- Is any information needed to answer now missing?

DF-027 Audit adapted materials for lost meaning or unsupported simplification

All grades

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Someone simplified it. You want to know what went with the difficulty.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Compare this adapted [GRADE] [SUBJECT] material against the original.

Tell me:

- What ideas are missing from the adapted version
- Where simplifying has changed a claim rather than its wording – a hedged statement made absolute, a cause implied where the original said correlation
- Where subject vocabulary was removed that students actually need
- Whether the adapted version now says something the original does not
- Whether it is still demanding enough to be worth the lesson

Quote the specific places. Then tell me the single change that would restore the most meaning.

ORIGINAL: [PASTE IT]

ADAPTED: [PASTE IT]

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Check any changed claim yourself. That is the one that matters.
- Is the adapted version still worth a lesson?

EXTENSIONS

DF-028 Create an extension that deepens reasoning instead of adding more work

Grades 3-5, 6-8, 9-12

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

They finished in half the time and deserve better than more questions.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Design an extension for students who finish this [GRADE] [SUBJECT] task early:
[PASTE THE TASK]

It must demand harder thinking, not more of the same. Adding items, longer numbers or extra examples is not an extension.

Give me:

- The extension task
- What deeper thinking it demands, in one line
- Why a student who found the original easy will not find this trivial
- What it produces that is worth sharing with the class
- Something they can do with it if they finish that too

It should need no explanation from me, use only what is on their desk, and take
10-15 minutes.

If a student would experience this as punishment for working quickly, redesign it.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Would a fast finisher see this as reward or punishment?
- Does it genuinely need no explanation?

DF-029 Build a transfer challenge using a new context

Grades 3-5, 6-8, 9-12

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Testing whether the learning travels.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Write a transfer challenge on [TOPIC] for [GRADE] [SUBJECT].

We worked in this context: [DESCRIBE IT]

Give me a task using the same thinking in a context we have never used.

Include:

- The task
- What makes the context genuinely different, not cosmetically different
- What a student who learned the surface pattern will do, and where it fails
- The answer or range of acceptable answers
- What the response tells me about whether the learning transferred

The challenge must not require knowledge from the new context that students do not have. If it does, say so and change it.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Is the context genuinely new, or the same with new nouns?
- Does it need outside knowledge students lack?

DF-030 Design an open-ended investigation with clear evidence expectations

Grades 6-8, 9-12

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Open enough to be interesting, defined enough to be markable.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Design an open-ended investigation on [TOPIC] for [GRADE] [SUBJECT], taking [TIME].

It should have several defensible answers, and still be markable.

Give me:

- The question, open but bounded
- What students must produce regardless of the direction they take
- What counts as evidence here, and what does not
- Three directions a student might reasonably go, and whether each is productive
- The checkpoint that stops someone spending the whole time on a dead end
- What I look for to distinguish genuine investigation from wandering

Do not make it so open that a student cannot tell whether they have finished.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Could a student tell when they are done?
- Would you accept all three directions it named?

DF-031 Audit an extension for novelty, rigor and connection to the objective

All grades

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Before it goes into the folder for fast finishers.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Audit this [GRADE] [SUBJECT] extension task: [PASTE IT]

Original task and objective: [PASTE THEM]

Tell me:

- Whether it demands different thinking or just more of the same
- Whether it connects to the objective or has drifted to a different topic
- Whether a student who found the original hard could attempt any part of it
- Whether it needs explanation from me – if so, it fails as an extension
- Whether a student would read it as reward or punishment

Then tell me the single change that would most improve it, and whether it is worth keeping at all.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- If it says the extension is just more work, do you agree?
- Would you want to be given this task?

FLEXIBLE GROUPING

DF-032 Build temporary groups from anonymous learning evidence

Grades 3-5, 6-8, 9-12

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Groups for this lesson, from what the work showed.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Build groups for a [GRADE] [SUBJECT] lesson on [TOPIC] from these response patterns:

[DESCRIBE THE PATTERNS AND ROUGHLY HOW MANY STUDENTS. No names.]

Give me:

- The groups, defined by what each needs rather than by level
- What each group does, all of it worth doing
- How groups are formed so the class does not read them as ability
- Where I go first, and for how long
- The check at the end that tells me whether to keep or dissolve these groups

These groups last one lesson. Tell me what would make me change them tomorrow.

Do not name students, and do not create a group that is visibly the bottom one.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Could students decode the grouping?
- Does every group have work worth doing?

DF-033 Create a rotation plan for three changing instructional needs

Grades 3-5, 6-8, 9-12

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Three needs, one of you, one period.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Plan a rotation for a [MINUTES]-minute [GRADE] [SUBJECT] lesson with three groups needing different things:

Group 1 needs: [DESCRIBE]

Group 2 needs: [DESCRIBE]

Group 3 needs: [DESCRIBE]

Give me:

- The timing, with transitions counted in
- Which group I take first and why
- What the other two do that genuinely does not need me
- What each group leaves behind as evidence
- What I do if my group runs over, since it will
- The two-minute closing that brings all three together

Assume I cannot properly supervise the other two while teaching one. Tell me what to set up beforehand so that survives.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Can the unsupervised groups really work without you?
- Is the transition time honest?

DF-034 Plan mixed-readiness groups with meaningful roles and accountability

Grades 3-5, 6-8, 9-12

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Mixed groups, where the strongest student is not just the answer key.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Plan mixed-readiness groups for this [GRADE] [SUBJECT] task: [PASTE IT]

Groups of [NUMBER].

The task must need everyone. A stronger student explaining to weaker ones is not collaboration, and it is not their job.

Give me:

- How the task is structured so different contributions are genuinely needed
- Roles defined by the thinking they demand, not by clerical jobs
- What each student produces individually
- How I stop one student doing the work for the group
- What each student can answer at the end, whatever their role

Then tell me honestly whether a stronger student gains anything here. If not, say so.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Does the strongest student gain anything, or just teach?
- Could one student do it all?

DF-035 Audit a grouping plan for labels, access, movement and regrouping triggers

All grades

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Before the groups quietly become permanent.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Audit this [GRADE] [SUBJECT] grouping plan: [PASTE IT]

Tell me:

- Whether any group is identifiable as the low group – by name, task, seating, or what they get to talk about
- Whether a student could move between groups, and what would trigger that
- Whether every group's work is worth doing, or one is waiting
- Whether the physical arrangement works in a normal room
- What happens when a group member is absent
- Whether there is any plan to dissolve these groups, or they are now fixed

Then tell me the single change that would most reduce the risk of these becoming permanent ability groups.

Be direct. Groups that were formed once and never revisited are the thing I most need told.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- When did you last change these groups? That is the real question.
- Is any group waiting rather than working?